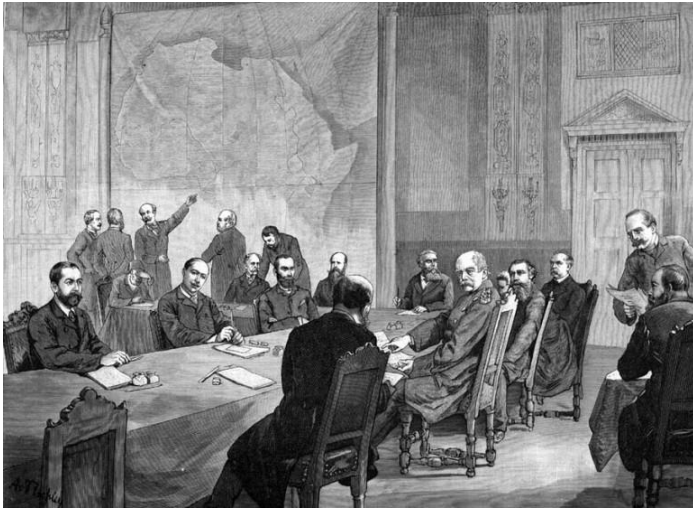


The Berlin Conference



Purpose

The Berlin Conference established ground rules for European **conquest** in Africa, a huge continent with an unusual climate, resources, and surface features. Africa is surrounded by water, so people from Europe, North America, and Asia could reach it by boat.

Colonies were established up and down the African coast by the

mid-nineteenth century. The Industrial Revolution, starting in Great Britain, further fueled the desire for cheap labor, raw materials, and new markets. This competition between European nations resulted in conflict. They felt the need to establish rules for dealing with one another in their desire to take over Africa. The hope was by setting up guidelines, they would avoid bloodshed and competition for African resources.

Attendees

Portugal proposed the Berlin Conference. It started on November 15, 1884 in Germany led by their chancellor, Otto von Bismarck. When the Berlin Conference began, 80% of Africa was still under local and traditional control. There were fourteen countries represented at the Berlin Conference: Austria-Hungary, Belgium, Denmark, France, Germany, Great Britain, Italy, the Netherlands, Portugal, Russia, Spain, Sweden-Norway (unified at the time), Turkey, and the United States of America. Nations with the most control in Africa at the time were

France, Germany, Great Britain, and Portugal, so they had the largest **input**.



Topics of Discussion

The slave trade was a major topic discussed at the Berlin Conference. Even though some resolutions were passed to end the slave trade, the conference mainly resulted in the division of Africa among European nations. They had no regard for any cultural or **linguistic** (language) boundaries already established by the **indigenous** African people.

Berlin Act

The members at the Berlin Conference wrote a document called the Berlin Act. Article 34 stated when a country took possession of an African nation, or named themselves a "protectorate" of one, they had to inform all other nations. If they failed to do this, their claim was not recognized. The Berlin Act was a new change to how countries interacted with one another. They made rules for controlling other nations to avoid war among themselves.



Consequences

The Berlin Act resulted in terrible consequences for the continent of Africa. Eventually African nations regained their independence, but the damage was already done. Many nations were unaware of how to run a country on their own after being controlled for such a long period. They lost their identity as their own nation. Many countries in Africa are still experiencing hardships due to these years of imperialism.

IT'S ALL ABOUT YOUR PERSPECTIVE!

Viewpoints of Imperialism in Africa

Read each viewpoint of imperialism in Africa and answer the questions that follow.

Imperialism: A German Viewpoint- Summary of a passage written by Friedrich Fabri in his book, *Does Germany Need Colonies?* published in 1879.

Should Germany begin on the road to imperialism? I believe we should. For one, we are an industrial nation. In order to maintain our factories and produce our goods we need access to natural resources. Resources like rubber, petroleum, manganese for steel, and palm oil for machinery is necessary and can be found in Africa and Asia.

Obtaining colonies will also benefit our economy. Obtaining colonies in faraway lands will open up new markets to trade our goods, and buy items that we do not produce. Colonies will provide our bankers with new business enterprises and project to invest money in.

Participating in Imperialism will strengthen our military and defend our nation. Our steam powered merchant ships and naval vessels require coal to operate. Colonies spread throughout Africa would provide all of our ships with a place to pick up coal and supplies.

By engaging in Imperialism we can limit the power of our competitors, Britain and France. We can prevent territory from falling into their hands, and halt further expansion. Germany would weaken their trade and keep colonial profits from going to Britain and France.

Lastly, taking part in Imperialism would increase national pride in Germany. If we successfully obtain colonies we will show the world that we are a strong nation. We will provide a place for our increasing population to live and work. By obtaining colonies, we can restore Germany's position as the most prestigious, important, and influential nation in Europe.

1) Does Fabri believe that Germany should participate in Imperialism?

- A. Yes B. No

2) Which of the following is **not** a reason Fabri gave to support his opinion?

- A. Germany is an industrial nation and will have more access to natural resources.
B. Colonies will provide new business enterprises and projects in which to invest.
C. Imperialism will weaken Germany's military, making it better for the people of Germany.
D. Imperialism will restore Germany's position as an influential nation.

3) Which of the following best supports Fabri's claim that Imperialism will strengthen their national pride?

- A. Obtaining colonies will show the world that Germany is a strong nation.
B. They are an industrial nation that needs raw materials.
C. Obtaining colonies will benefit Germany economically.
D. Colonies will help strengthen Germany's military.

4) Which of the following is **not** a raw material that Fabri pointed out they could obtain from Africa?

- A. Rubber B. Petroleum C. Cotton D. Palm Oil

5) Which two nations does Fabri point out as Germany's largest competitors?

- A. Spain & France B. France & Britain C. Portugal & Spain D. France & Portugal

Imperialism: A French Viewpoint- Paraphrased from Paul Leroy Beaulieu in the late 19th century.

The great part of the world is inhabited by barbarian tribes or savages who participate in wars without end and brutal customs. They know very little about the arts and sciences. They do not know how to work, invent, or exploit their land and its natural resources. They live in little groups of poverty spread throughout a large territory which if used correctly, could provide much food and riches.

This area of the world needs civilized people to intervene. It is not natural for the civilized people of the west to gather the marvels of science, art, and civilization and not share the opportunities with the savages in need. We have the duty to spread knowledge of medicine, law, and Christian religion. Such a transformation of a barbarian country cannot be accomplished by business or economic relations alone.

6) Which of the following is not a word used by Beaulieu to describe Africans?

- A. Barbarians
- B. Savages
- C. Brutal
- D. Civilized

7) Who is the intended audience of this selection by Beaulieu?

- A. Africans
- B. Christians
- C. Savages
- D. Tribes

8) Which of the following is not a reason Beaulieu gives that people must intervene in Africa?

- A. Africans do not know how to work.
- B. Africans did not know how to invent.
- C. Africans use their natural resources.
- D. Africans are barbarians.

9) Which sentence least supports the central idea of Beaulieu's writing?

- A. They know very little about the arts and sciences.
- B. The great part of the world is inhabited by barbarian tribes or savages who participate in wars without end and brutal customs.
- C. It is not natural for the civilized people of the west to gather the marvels of science, art, and civilization and not share the opportunities with the savages in need.
- D. This area of the world need civilized people to intervene.

10) How do Fabri and Beaulieu's viewpoint of Imperialism differ?

- A. Fabri thinks natives of Africa need to be more civilized.
- B. Beaulieu thinks natives of Africa need to be more civilized.
- C. Fabri thinks natives of Africa are savages.
- D. Beaulieu thinks natives of Africa are nice people.